China's Reusable Rocket Race: Chasing SpaceX

SpaceX Falcon 9 Reference 22.8t LEO · First recovery 2015 · Single booster reused 25+ times · 300+ launches in 2025 · $2,720/kg

LandSpace

Closest

Zhuque-3

Payload: 21.3t LEO (Falcon 9 class)

Dec 2025: Orbit success, recovery failed

Next recovery: 2026 Q2 · Reflight target: Q4

Space Pioneer

Tianlong-3

72m tall · 9 engines · 17-18t LEO

Stainless steel body (like Starship) · Designed for 10 reuses

Ready at Jiuquan · First flight: ~Mar 2026

Funding: $350M · Annual production target: 30

iSpace

Hyperbola-3

69m tall · 8.5t LEO (reusable mode)

Completed 2 VTVL tests in 2023

Sea recovery prep · 2026 first orbital flight

Galactic Energy

Pallas-1

7t LEO · Designed for 25 reuses

Jan 17, 2026: First flight failed

Funding: $336M · Needs to recover from failure

State-Owned (CASC)

Long March 10 Reusable Variant

5m diameter · State resources backing

Feb 2026: Low-altitude demo flight success

Target: 2026 H1 first flight

More Players

Deep Blue Aerospace · Nebula-1 · Multiple hover tests

Orienspace · Gravity-2 · 25+t LEO

CAS Space · Kinetica-2 · 12t LEO

11+ reusable rocket programs in parallel

2025 Funding: 26.6B yuan ($3.8B) · 137 rounds · STAR Market fast-track IPO for reusable rocket firms

How Big Is the Gap?

SpaceX (2025)

300+ launches · Single booster reused 25+ times · $2,720/kg · 60% global share

VS

China Commercial (2025)

<30 orbital launches (total) · 0 successful recoveries · ~10 years behind

China doesn't need to "beat" SpaceX — just needs autonomous capability. Space access is the next strategic high ground after chips.

Mega-constellations create launch demand · Brute-force + policy support · Behind does not mean without opportunity

Sources: SpaceNews · NASASpaceFlight · CNBC · SpaceWatch Global · The Wire China · SCMP